



Incident handler's journal

Date: 7/13/2026	Entry: #1
Description	Documenting a ransomware security incident
Tool(s) used	None
The 5 W's	• Who: An organized group of unethical hackers known to target organizations in healthcare and transportation industries • What: A ransomware security incident • When: 9:00 am on a Tuesday • Where: A small US healthcare clinic specializing in primary-care services • Why: The hackers sent phishing emails to employees, which contained malicious attachments that installed malware onto employee computers when downloaded. With the malware, the attackers deployed ransomware that encrypted files critical to business operations and demanded a large sum of money in exchange for the decryption key. It seems that the attackers' motivation was purely financial.
Additional notes	1. Employees should be better educated about phishing attacks. 2. Should the company pay the ransom?

Date: 7/17/2026	Entry: #2
Description	Determining the identity of a suspicious file
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal
The 5 W's	• Who: An unknown attacker • What: A malware security incident • When: From 1:11pm to 1:20pm • Where: A financial services company

	● Why: The attacker sent an employee an email with a password-protected attachment. The employee downloaded and opened the attachment, which executed a malicious payload on the employee's computer. The attacker's motive appeared to be to gain backdoor access to the company's systems.
Additional notes	From VT analysis, it is clear that the payload file is malicious.

Date: 7/17/2026	Entry: #3
Description	Evaluating a phishing security alert
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal
The 5 W's	● Who: An unknown attacker ○ Name: Clyde West ○ Sender: Def Communications ○ Email: 76tguyhh6tgfrt7tg.su ○ IP: 114.114.114.114 ● What: A phishing and malware security incident ● When: Wednesday, July 20, 2022 09:30:14 AM ● Where: A financial services company called Inergy ● Why: The attacker sent an email to HR pretending to be interested in an Infrastructure Engineer role at the company. The email is clearly a phishing attempt: it is full of misspellings; the name, sender, and sender email do not match; there is a password-protected attachment claiming to be a resume/cover letter. Analysis shows that the attachment is malicious.
Additional notes	This alert should be escalated to a level-two SOC analyst for further investigation and action.

Date: 7/20/2026	Entry: #4
Description	Reviewing a final report
Tool(s) used	None
The 5 W's	• Who: An unknown attacker • What: Data theft • When: December 22, 2022 at 3:13pm PT • Where: A mid-sized retail company • Why: The attacker exploited a web vulnerability to use forced browsing to access thousands of customer purchase–confirmation pages. The attacker exfiltrated the PII and SPII of roughly 50,000 customers and demanded ransom payment via email. The attacker’s motive appeared to be purely financial.
Additional notes	The web vulnerability should be patched—ideally something that obfuscates order numbers in the URL, thus preventing malicious actors from accessing sensitive information using forced browsing.

Reflections/Notes:

1. Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?
These activities were relatively straightforward. The most challenging part was determining the relevant information from the given scenarios and presenting it in a concise manner.
2. Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course?
I have gained a deeper understanding of incident detection and response from taking this course. I know better than I did before how all the stages work together in the lifecycle and how each tool (packet analyzers, IDSs, and SIEMs) support the process.
3. Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?
I enjoyed using VirusTotal the most. It was more hands-on than the rest of the activities documented here. I liked learning how to parse through the important information it provides and connecting it to the Pyramid of Pain.